Fluency practice

Securing the essential steps

Use fluency practice when students understand a process but perform it slowly or inconsistently. Secure accuracy before increasing pace, volume or complexity.

How to do it well

1 Identify the component. Locate the decision or action that is accurate but hesitant, or repeatedly disrupts the whole task.

2 Set a short focused practice set. Keep the target clear and begin with familiar forms.

3 Inspect early attempts. Correct the faulty step before it is repeated and provide a small prompt or model where needed.

4 Increase efficiency. Reduce prompts and encourage smoother execution while preserving accuracy and explanation.

5 Recombine and revisit. Use the component in a complete task, then return after a delay and introduce useful variation.

What this sounds like

“For these six items, practise selecting the correct operation. Accuracy comes first. After that decision is secure, we will complete the full problems.”

Classroom example. In Music, students practise a short rhythmic component that interrupts a longer performance. The teacher first secures accuracy, then smoother execution and finally recombination with the full phrase. Later rehearsal revisits the same component. Faster playing is useful only when it preserves the timing and technique being practised.

Top tips that make the technique work

Practise the bottleneck. A short set on the difficult component may be more useful than repeatedly completing the whole task.

Keep correct models available initially. Students should not spend the practice interval repeatedly rehearsing an error.

Increase speed cautiously. Fluency includes accurate, efficient performance; rushing alone is not the aim.

Use purposeful variation. Vary features that require attention while keeping the target skill stable.

Include delayed practice. Smooth performance immediately after modelling can fade unless revisited.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Monitor early items and correct promptly.	Timed competition before the method is secure.
Build towards accurate independent performance.	Repeating identical items without attending to their structure.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation. Some links support part of this guide rather than the whole technique.

Barton - Purposeful Practice | DistillED - Require and Monitor Independent Practice